

A Star Fleet Battles™ Rule Proposal

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(E____.0) SWALLOW ROUNDS

The Swallow is an alternate ADD round, consisting of a small, hyper-fast drone frame (having the same form-factor as a Type-VI drone) equipped with a miniature warp reactor; the reactor is "programmable", and designed to create a momentary warp signature similar to that of a specific Size Class 5 or larger ship. If successful, a Swallow can fool a warp-seeking weapon into thinking it has intercepted its target and therefore cause the warhead to detonate. This technology was initially developed by the Federation in early Y174, in response to the "shatterpack" (a scatterpack with 12 Type-VI drones), and quickly stolen by all empires using ADDs by the end of Y175.

(E____.1) DEPLOYMENT

(E____.11) **PERMITTED RACKS:** A Swallow round may be used in any base-, ship- or shuttle-mounted ADD launcher, including Type-G (FD3.7) drone racks. However, it may not be used in a Type-E (FD3.5) drone rack.

(E____.12) **ADD ROUND REPLACED:** Each Swallow round replaces an ADD round, at the same cost as replacing an ADD round with a Type-VI drone (E5.41).

(E____.13) **AVAILABILITY:** Swallow rounds have Limited (FD10.63) availability the first year they are introduced (units with six-round ADD launchers may have a single Swallow *per* launcher), and have Restricted availability the next year. They become Generally available (to all empires using ADDs) in Y180, except the Orion Pirates (for whom they remain Restricted until Y188). **ADD reloads never contain Swallows**, but additional Swallows may be purchased under the same rules/restrictions as purchasing additional Type-VI drones for an ADD rack.

(E____.131) Swallow rounds may not be placed on or launched from Starfish (FD15.0) or Stonefish (FD17.0) drones, as the drone frame lacks the necessary fire control support.

(E____.132) Swallows cannot replace Type-VI drone sub-munitions in multi-warhead (FD8.0) or Stingray (FD16.0) drones, because the drone frame is not an ADD launcher (and even if it were, it still lacks the necessary fire control support).

(E____.133) Swallows cannot replace Type-VI drones on a Seeking Weapons Drogue (G34.31) because the drogue system is not an ADD launcher; although, if an ADD-equipped drogue platform were created, then (G34.173) would allow it to use Swallow rounds.

(E____.134) If a fighter is capable of using RALADs (J12.0), then (J12.11) permits launching Swallow rounds from the fighter's launch rails, as restricted by (J12.12). The cost calculation (to replace the fighter's normal drones with Swallows) in (J12.13) is used instead of (E____.12), but the availability rule in (E____.12) supercedes (J12.13).

(E____.2) OPERATION

(E____.21) **DIRECT-FIRE WEAPON:** A Swallow is a direct-fire weapon; the decision to fire a Swallow instead of a "normal" ADD round is made at the instant of firing. Firing a Swallow round does not restrict the further

operation of an ADD rack; specifically, the Swallow is **not** a Type-VI drone and (E5.42) does not apply to it. Similarly, a rack, or fighter rail (J12.1), must be eligible to fire an ADD or it cannot launch a Swallow.

(E____.22) **FIRE CONTROL REQUIRED:** Swallow rounds have the same fire-control requirements as an ADD round (*e.g.*, lock-on required). A Swallow does not require a control channel (F3.2) to guide it.

(E____.23) **TARGET IDENTITY REQUIRED:** A Swallow only affects warp-seeking weapons (E____.42) that the firing unit (or an allied unit) has identified as such using Aegis (D13.31), Labs (G4.231), Probes (G5.25) and/or Scout Functions (G24.252). Terrain, such as Sunspots (P11.0), may disrupt the communications (P11.1) needed for allied units to share the drone identity information required to program the Swallow's tiny reactor to precisely emulate the target's warp signature.

(E____.24) **SELF-DEFENSE NOT REQUIRED:** Any eligible allied unit may deploy a Swallow; a warp-seeker does not have to be targeted on the unit launching the Swallow in order to be distracted.

(E____.25) **TARGETING:** Swallow rounds are targeted on a HEX, not a specific drone, and may be fired out to a true range of three hexes. Swallows may not be fired past an effective range of three hexes, even if the true range is three hexes or less. The target of the warp-seekers must be known and specified when the emulating Swallow is launched.

(E____.26) **PROCEDURE:** When a Swallow is fired, the player designates the target hex, then rolls one die.

(E____.261) This roll is modified by the same factors (E5.16) (E5.62) as an ADD. Crew Quality and Legendary Officers may also affect this roll, as they would any other direct-fire weapon.

(E____.262) The fire is resolved by the ANTI-DRONE PROBABILITY OF HIT CHART (E5.6).

(E____.27) **PROHIBITED:** Swallow rounds may not be fired by a unit using Erratic Maneuvering (C10.0); or, by a unit that is cloaked (G13.0), even during fade-in or fade-out.

(E____.3) EFFECT

(E____.31) **TARGET HEX MISSED:** If the target hex is "missed", then the Swallow generated its warp signature too far from any hostile warp-seeking weapon to attract notice. There is no other effect, and no attempt is made, for the purposes of (E____.41), to distract warp-seeking weapons.

(E____.32) **TARGET HEX HIT:** If the target hex is "hit", then for EACH hostile warp-seeking weapon in the hex, that has been positively identified and is tracking *the specified* (E____.23) allied Size Class 5 or larger target, roll one die; on a 1-3, the Swallow is successful; otherwise, it fails.

(E____.321) Crew Quality and Legendary Officers do not affect this roll.

(E____.322) Built-in ECCM, or ECCM provided to the warp-seeking weapon under (F3.331), does not affect the roll.

(E____.33) **SUCCESS:** If the Swallow is successful, then the warp-seeking weapon is fooled into thinking it has intercepted its target, and detonates its warhead.

(E____.331) Active guidance (FD5.2) does not prevent the warp-seeking

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weapon from being fooled.

(E____.332) If a warp-seeker is fooled and detonates, there is no "collateral damage" (J3.3); the prematurely-exploding weapon does not damage any other units in the hex (it veers off to "attack" the Swallow).

(E____.34) **FAILURE:** If the Swallow failed, then the warp-seeking weapon was not deceived by the generated signature. There is no other effect on that seeking weapon. The failure is with respect to a specific warp-seeking weapon, and does not prevent the same Swallow from being successful against other eligible warp-seeking weapons in the same hex on the same impulse.

(E____.4) LIMITATIONS

(E____.41) **FIRE RATE LIMITED:** For any given hex containing warp-seeking weapons, only one Swallow may attempt to distract a specific weapon on any given impulse.

(E____.411) Normal ADD rounds may be fired into the target hex of a Swallow on the same impulse (perhaps to destroy drones that are not warp-seekers, or drones that have not been identified; or, if the firing unit has Aegis Fire Control, to fire normal ADD rounds at warp-seeking drones that the Swallow failed to distract).

(E____.412) A Swallow will not interfere with other seeking weapons launched from the firing unit on the same impulse, even if they are warp-seekers.

(E____.413) Since Swallows affect only hostile warp-seekers, a unit cannot fire a Swallow round into a hex to interfere with an enemy Swallow, or to prevent, under (E____.41), an enemy from using their own Swallow.

(E____.414) Aegis Fire Control may not be used to fire a second Swallow, programmed to emulate the same target ship, into a given hex on the same impulse (it takes too long to determine success or failure of the first shot). However, there is no requirement that a Swallow round be used as the first Aegis-controlled weapon.

(E____.414) Multiple allied Swallows may be fired into the same hex on a given impulse, provided that each Swallow is programmed to emulate a different target ship, and that at least one warp-seeking weapon tracking each of the target ships has been previously identified.

(E____.42) **WARP-SEEKERS ONLY:** A Swallow can only distract warp-seeking weapons guided under (FD5.11). This includes Type-K (FP13.0) Plasma Torpedoes, but excludes all other types of plasma torpedoes.

(E____.421) A Swallow can only affect warp-seeking weapons in the target hex (E____.26) the impulse the Swallow is fired.

(E____.422) A Swallow will NOT affect in-flight allied warp-seeking weapons, even if they are tracking a Size Class 5 or larger unit (Swallows attempt to deceive warp-seekers by emulating the warp-signature of their target, so they cannot fool a warp-seeker into attacking a target that has a different warp-signature).

(E____.43) **SIZE CLASS:** Warp-seeking weapons not tracking a unit that is Size Class 5 or larger cannot be distracted by a Swallow; that is, a Swallow cannot function as Chaff (D11.0). An ADD-equipped shuttle

(e.g., MRS) or fighter (or bomber) could launch a Swallow, but only to distract warp-seekers targeted on an allied Size Class 5 or larger unit (e.g., not for self-defense).

(E____.44) **NO OTHER EFFECTS:** A Swallow does not generate any EW or EW-like effects. Swallow rounds cannot damage anything directly. They cannot be used to damage mines (including DEFSATs), drones, plasma torpedoes, shuttles, ships, or asteroids. While a Swallow generates a warp signature that (briefly) *simulates* a ship, the effect does not last long enough to trigger mines or count as a target for the purposes of (M2.15).

(E____.45) **WILD WEASEL VOIDED:** Launching a Swallow will void a Wild Weasel, without regard to the success or failure of the Swallow.

(E____.46) **ESG DESTROYS:** If fired through an active ESG, or into an active ESG hex, the ESG will destroy the Swallow, before it can attempt to distract warp-seekers, without significant damage to the ESG field.

(E____.47) **BLOCKED BY WEB:** A Swallow cannot be fired into or through a web, even by a Tholian unit. It may, however, be fired out of a web hex into an unwebbed hex (effective range is not affected).

(E____.48) **TERRAIN INTERACTION:** Generally, a Swallow round is affected by Terrain as an ADD round, subject to the following exceptions:

(E____.481) Swallow rounds are relatively fragile, and are destroyed, before they can have any effect, if they are fired into or through a Gravity Wave (P9.0); this forms an exception to (P9.316).

(E____.482) A unit in an atmosphere hex, including a Ground Base, cannot fire a Swallow round; this creates a technical exception to (P2.548). The atmospheric drag will cause the Swallow to automatically miss (E____.31). A Swallow fired *into* an atmosphere hex is destroyed by the friction of entry, without appreciable damage to the planet or any unit, and before it can have any effect.

(E____.483) Similarly, Swallows are destroyed, before they can have any effect, if they are fired into or through a Dust Cloud (P13.0). This forms a technical exception to (P13.3), in that a Swallow is immediately destroyed upon entering a Dust Cloud hex (this includes if the Swallow is launched by a unit that is in such a hex), rather than taking damage.

(E____.484) While it is technically possible to launch a Swallow within a nebula (P6.0), since warp-seeking weapons will not function (P6.6) there, it would seem rather pointless. There might be a corner case where a unit IN a nebula hex fires a Swallow at an adjacent (or nearby) target hex OUTSIDE the nebula in order to distract warp-seeking weapons tracking an allied unit OUTSIDE the nebula; however, a Swallow that passes through one nebula hex is destroyed the moment it enters a second nebula hex; in this case, due to the fragile nature of the Swallow, the destruction happens before it can have any effect.

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